

Title:

We Are Just Tired

Keywords:

tiredness, exhaustion, mental health, coping strategies, Nigeria, workplace stress, daily pressures, burnout, resilience, fatigue, societal expectations, stress management, limited support, personal wellbeing

Short Description:

This article explores why people feel constantly exhausted, the daily pressures that contribute to burnout, the challenges in accessing mental health support, and the ways people cope when formal help is scarce. It highlights the personal and systemic impact of chronic tiredness and suggests steps for managing it.

WE ARE JUST TIRED

Lately, it feels like everyone is tired.

Not the kind of tired that sleep fixes. The kind that stays with you through the day. The kind you carry while replying to messages, sitting in traffic, meeting deadlines, and pretending you're fine.

You hear it in sighs before voice notes. You see it in slow replies and missed calls. You feel it when simple things take too much effort.

For many, life has become a constant management task. Managing money. Managing work. Managing expectations. Even rest feels rushed.

And still, the message is the same: *keep going. Be strong. Handle it.*

So people do. They endure. They adjust. They survive. But over time, that survival turns into exhaustion.

This piece looks at where that tiredness comes from, why help is hard to find, how people are coping, and what happens when coping is all there is.

Because when everyone feels this way, it stops being personal.

Where the Exhaustion Is Coming From

This tiredness doesn't come from one thing. It builds from pressures happening at the same time. Most days start before the body is ready and end long after the mind has shut down.

Some of the pressures that pile up include:

1. **Money stress:** Salaries that barely cover rent, transport, school fees, and groceries. Side hustles are no longer optional; they are necessary.
2. **Work pressure:** Long hours, constant availability, impossible targets. Expectations rarely pause for your energy levels.
3. **Commute stress:** Hours lost in traffic. Leaving home early. Getting back late. Starting and ending the day already drained.
4. **Social comparison:** Seeing others relocate, get new jobs, or "*figure life out*" online while you feel stuck.

On top of that, society pushes the same message:

- Being tired is a weakness
- Rest feels like laziness
- Saying "*I'm struggling*" feels risky
- Smiling and managing becomes the default

Women often feel this more sharply: work responsibilities rarely reduce home expectations. Emotional support is expected. Strength is assumed.

How the Body Reacts

Over time, this pressure affects the body and mind in several ways. Like you:

- Waking up tired even after sleep
- Losing focus or motivation
- Short patience and irritability
- Skipping meals or living on caffeine
- Putting personal care and rest aside
- Feeling like you're always behind.

Why Help Is Hard to Find

When this tiredness turns into something heavier, affecting your sleep, mood, or focus, you might start to think: *Maybe I should get help.*

Then reality hits. In Nigeria, help is often hard to reach. Even when people know they need support, the options are limited, expensive, and far away.

Awareness Exists, But Access Lags

People are talking about mental health more than before. There are:

- Online communities and WhatsApp groups
- Social media hashtags and campaigns
- Occasional wellbeing workshops in schools or offices

People can name stress, burnout, and fatigue. They know it affects the body and mind.

But knowing is not the same as getting help. Awareness has moved faster than access.

Mental Health Services Are Limited

Even in big cities in Lagos:

- Psychologists and psychiatrists are few; one counsellor may serve hundreds of people
- Clinics are often in expensive areas with hours that clash with work
- Appointments can take weeks, sometimes months
- Fees are high and often unaffordable

And outside major cities, these options are almost non-existent.

Workplaces Aren't Much Better

Offices often fail to support employees properly:

- Long hours, back-to-back meetings, and high performance expectations
- HR may mention wellness programs or counselling on paper, but rarely make them accessible
- Sessions can be during work hours, limited in number, or stigmatized, making staff reluctant to attend

For many, exhaustion meets bureaucracy at work. People are expected to keep performing, no matter how drained they feel.

How We're Managing and Sometimes Struggling

When formal support is out of reach, people find ways to get by. Some of it works. Some of it doesn't.

Small Ways We Cope

- Short breaks: Stepping away from a screen or a task for a few minutes to breathe or stretch
- Laughter: Joking with colleagues, friends, or family to release tension
- Confiding in others: Sharing feelings with someone trusted
- Music, podcasts, or TV: Temporary escape from stress
- Using meditation or wellness apps
- Self-medicating without guidance

These actions don't fix the root problem, but they help people keep going for the day.

Riskier Habits

- Skipping meals or relying too much on caffeine to stay awake
- Pushing through illness or pain to meet work deadlines
- Withdrawing from friends or family when drained
- Over-relying on self-help routines without professional guidance

These habits are understandable; they make sense in the moment, but if repeated over weeks or months, they can worsen exhaustion, affect health, and strain relationships.

Workplace Strain

At work, coping often means hiding struggles:

- Pushing through fatigue while trying to meet expectations

- Avoiding counselling or HR programs due to stigma or inconvenient timing
- Appearing “fine” even when mentally or physically drained

Managers may praise endurance, thereby normalizing exhaustion. For many, survival in the office becomes a skill rather than a choice.

When Coping Becomes a Risk

Managing daily fatigue only works up to a point. Over time, the shortcuts, small breaks, and improvisations stop being enough.

Health and Body

- [Chronic exhaustion can lead to headaches, back pain, digestive issues, and weakened immunity.](#)
- Mental strain can become anxiety, depression, or burnout.
- Skipping meals, overworking, and constant stress affect sleep, focus, and overall energy.

Work and Productivity

- Pushing through fatigue reduces efficiency and creativity.
- Errors increase, deadlines are harder to meet, and opportunities are missed.
- Offices may notice “*resilient employees*,” but resilience here is forced, not healthy.

Family and Relationships

- Tiredness spreads. Irritability or withdrawal affects partners, children, and extended family.
- Caregiving responsibilities may clash with personal limits, causing friction and frustration at home.

Communities and Society

- Those outside major cities face almost no support, widening inequality.
- Exhaustion becomes shared: workplaces, families, and communities all feel the strain.

What appears to be endurance or resilience is often **forced adaptation**. People manage because they must, not because it’s optional. Survival becomes a constant, and the cost is visible in health, relationships, and daily life.

What We Can Do About It

At Home

- **Set boundaries:** Give yourself time to rest without guilt.
- **Share responsibilities:** Split chores, caregiving, and daily tasks with family when possible.
- **Notice your limits:** It's okay to say no or postpone a task.

At Work

- **Use available support:** Employee Assistance Programs or counselling services, even if limited, are worth trying.
- **Talk to HR:** Push for flexible hours, wellbeing initiatives, or realistic workloads.
- **Small pauses matter:** Step away for a few minutes, stretch, or take a walk to reset your mind.

Personal Habits

- **Rest when you can:** Even short naps or a calm evening routine help.
- **Healthy basics:** Food, water, sleep, and movement are not luxuries; they're survival tools.
- **Lean on trusted people:** Friends, family, or community networks can help you cope safely.
- **Spiritual routines:** Prayer, reflection, or meditation can provide real comfort and renewal, helping you regain energy and perspective during exhaustion.

Looking Ahead

Exhaustion is not just personal. It reflects how life, work, and systems are structured. Awareness is growing, and conversations about stress, mental health, and wellbeing are happening, but action is needed.

Even small steps, repeated consistently, can change the experience of everyday life. Pausing, asking for help, and sharing the load aren't weaknesses; they're strengths. And strength becomes stronger when it's shared.

I want to hear from you: What small changes have helped you manage your tiredness? Or what do you wish could change in your work, home, or daily life to make things easier?

